



**Trailblazer:** Hailing from a humble background in Barbados, Sobers rose to become one of the greatest cricketers, and arguably, the greatest all-rounder.

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the innings recalled the majestic display in glowing terms. One particular shot off Lillee seemed to reach the fence before the bowler was a step into his follow-through.

World cricket was enriched by his astonishing consistency and relentless desire to dominate. He could bat in any position and play virtually every shot in the book.

The six sixes off six balls against Glamorgan in 1968 was a first. The bowler, left-arm spinner Malcolm Nash, was grateful to Sobers for



helping him into the record books.

Fans flocked to watch him bat, bowl and field. Many turned up simply to marvel at his athleticism and style: collars up, the lazy walk from slip to slip.

Sobers was a star, a handsome cricketer whose presence drew women to cricket grounds in large numbers. His colleagues were envious of his immense following.

Hailing from a humble background in Barbados, Sobers rose to become one of the greatest cricketers and, arguably, the greatest all-rounder. He could bowl fast, tease you with spin and unleash the chinaman. He was a wizard.

His contemporaries learned by watching him closely. Sobers knew he was a role model for many who wished to emulate him, and he shared his wisdom generously.

He would always remain a revered figure for Sunil Gavaskar, who was fortunate to earn three reprieves at Port of Spain in 1971, including one from Sobers. In the preceding Test, the same Sobers had plucked an impossible catch to dismiss K. Jayantilal, who never got another chance to play for India.

Sobers held Ajit Wadekar and Bishan Singh Bedi (pic, above) in high esteem. In 2010, he travelled to Mumbai when noted cricket journalist Dwarkanath Sanzgiri felicitated the Indian team of 1971 for their series victories in West Indies and England.

Sobers lent his name to attract sponsors and raise funds for the

Indians and, remarkably, refused to take his share. It was an incredible night, with cricket stories flowing until morning. Wadekar and Bedi sat attentively, soaking in the anecdotes as Sobers recalled those glorious times.

There was none like Sobers.

One anecdote from the Tied Test in 1960 captured his genius.

Australian skipper Richie Benaud, a crafty leg-spinner, was locked in a captivating duel with Sobers, who had smashed a century in the first innings.

At one point, Benaud, seeing Sobers looking to step out, slipped in a flipper. Benaud was convinced he had his man with the well-concealed delivery. Sobers realised his mistake, but followed through on his commitment with a flourish that sent the ball flashing past Benaud.

It remains one of the golden moments from that great contest, when two masters tested each other's finesse.

Sobers stayed in touch with the game despite his failing health. His frail figure pained admirers who remembered him as a debonair presence on the cricket field.

Sobers would surely have lorded over the T20 format, given his dashing strokeplay and his ability to fox batters with the ball. He was the original god of cricket, and those who saw him play in the flesh were blessed.

Those who did not can visit YouTube to discover the true meaning of the art of cricket.